STATE SCAN

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RANJAN RAHI

POLL ROLL CALL Officials check forms for the Election Commission's Special Intensive Revision in Bihar, at Jalalpur, Patna district

BIHAR

BIHARI VS 'BAHARI'

'Native' or not? The debate creates a domino effect beyond electoral rolls. Nitish puts a binding clause on gender quotas: it will be exclusively for women domiciled in Bihar now

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

BIHAR, IN MANY WAYS, IS GROUND ZERO for post-Mandal reservation politics. Innovations on that had started back in 2013, when the Nitish Kumar government introduced a landmark policy, reserving 35 per cent of police jobs—within caste quotas and beyond—for women. By 2016, this policy was extended to all government posts in the state. Now, nearly a decade later, there's a new twist to reservation policies.

Amid a raging debate about the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and its concomitant focus on natives and outsiders, a piece of evolution has crept into that old schema of quotas that readjusts it to this new reality of electoral politics.

In a quiet yet politically charged manoeuvre on July 8, the Bihar cabinet amended its flagship gender quota, restricting the 35 per cent state government jobs exclusively to women domiciled in Bihar. For the first time, aspirants from outside the state—*baharis*—have been formally excluded. On paper, this appears a mere tightening of bureaucratic criteria.

Politically, however, the chain of cause and effect is clear. The SIR process is creating an atmosphere polarised on nativism, of the sort only occasionally seen before in Bihar. In 2015, for instance, Nitish had drummed up some passions about Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "DNA remark" and framed it as a conflict between "an outsider and